nursing coffees. I read the room, follow suit and order the same. Their body language, even out of the dim lights, is a sickening concoction of that awful, patronising sympathy no one wants and palpable, pre-emptive self-defence.

My brain is doing the maths and my heart is sinking as I go to shake their hands. I feel like Joe Pesci in *Goodfellas*, ushered into a room under the impression that I'm going to get made, only to be shot. You fuckers. They're going to tell me something I don't want to be told, aren't they? Something I've been swerving, darting, shapeshifting, bowling through for my whole life. It's chased me for so long. I have half begun to feel it might never get me. I almost allowed myself to daydream that, somehow, I might be the only exception to the rule. But here it is – the career reaper – dressed as McCullum, Stokes and Key in the Dakota Hotel bar at midday in Manchester. They wouldn't choose to do this in a public bar though, would they? Maybe I'm paranoid. Maybe it is an appraisal.

I haven't yet had time to lean on one eventuality or the other when the words come sharply, if reticently, out of McCullum's mouth. They are organised and rehearsed, sure and slow: 'We are looking to the future,' he says, as the sides of the room start to blur. 'We don't think you're going to make it to Australia in 18 months' time and we want to see who would be good for that series and have the time to work it out.' Oh, this isn't even going to be a negotiation. It isn't even a conversation, is it? I'm being *told*.

The last time England had tried to do this, it was a 45-second phone call from Andrew Strauss before the West Indies tour in early 2022. He had just said on the phone, incredibly bluntly and swiftly, 'There's no easy way to say this, but we're going in a different direction. We're giving younger players a go.' That was it. No further information. End of call. I didn't want to argue because my kids were in the car. I didn't mention it to them, I just drove them home, phoned Stuart Broad, who had been dropped too it turned out, and went to the gym. We took our combined 1,177 wickets and raged ourselves fitter. They called it a 'red ball reset'. It turned out the red ball reset needed resetting itself quite quickly and three months later we were back in. Strauss and I have never spoken about it since. I guess you'd rather be stabbed in the front than the back.

This time, it's different. It's both kinder and harsher, more sympathetic and more ruthless and, worst of all, nauseatingly final. Their faces are